

Japan Itinerary

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Japan: Temples, Trains & the Country That Resets Every Travel Standard You Had

Japan ruined us for other countries. Not in a dramatic way—we didn't come home weeping for Kyoto or composing haiku about ramen. But quietly, insistently, Japan reset certain standards: for public transport punctuality, for food at every price point, for the particular quality of attention that Japanese culture brings to almost everything, from sandwich packaging to temple maintenance to the ritual of handing back your change with two hands. After Japan, you notice when these things are missing. Which is, in most places, always.

We did the classic Golden Route—**Tokyo, Kyoto, Osaka**—with a side trip to **Nara** and an afternoon in **Hiroshima**. Two weeks. About 1,200 km of Shinkansen travel. More food than we've eaten in any comparable period of our lives.

Tokyo: The City That Contains Multitudes

Tokyo is not one city. It's twenty cities that happen to share a train network and a postal code. We spent five days there and felt like we barely began. **Shibuya**: the famous scramble crossing at rush hour, which is exactly as magnificent as advertised—the signal turns, pedestrians flood from every direction, somehow nobody collides, and then it reverses. You can watch it for an hour from the Shibuya Scramble Square observation deck and it never stops being extraordinary.

Harajuku on a Sunday: the Takeshita-dori street is sensory overload, neon and sugar and fashion that seems to come from alternate realities. We walked through it, emerged slightly dazed, and recovered with crepes from a street stall. Then: **Meiji Jingu Shrine**, a hundred meters away, where the forest swallows all that noise and replaces it with the sound of wind through camphor trees and the occasional wooden clack of Shinto rituals.

Japan holds contradictions in the same hand without apparent effort. Ancient and futuristic. Frantic and quiet. Formal and deeply playful. You stop trying to reconcile them and just experience both, often within the same block.

Kyoto: The City That Slows You Down

If Tokyo is acceleration, **Kyoto** is deceleration. The ancient capital of Japan carries its history lightly but seriously—17 UNESCO World Heritage Sites, more temples and shrines than you can visit in a week, a culture of traditional crafts and tea ceremony and geiko performances that continues with genuine intent rather than tourist theater.

We walked the **Philosopher's Path** in early morning, when the canal-side path of cherry trees was just beginning to lose its blossoms and the light was coming through the petals in a way that made everything look lit by a film crew. We visited **Fushimi Inari**—the shrine of ten thousand torii gates winding up the mountain—arriving at 6:30 a.m. before the crowds arrived, and stood in corridors of orange gates with nobody around us and felt very small in an extremely good way.

The **Arashiyama Bamboo Grove**: yes, it lives up to the photograph. The sound of bamboo in wind is unlike any other sound in the world, and walking through it feels like being inside a different kind of silence.

Osaka: Where Japan Eats

Osaka has a reputation as Japan's kitchen, and it more than earns it. The philosophy here is *kuidaore*—eat until you drop—and we committed to it with enthusiasm. **Dotonbori** at night: neon, food stalls, giant mechanical crabs above restaurant entrances, the smell of takoyaki (octopus balls) and yakitori everywhere. We ate standing up, we ate walking, we ate sitting on steps over a canal at midnight.

Kuromon Ichiba market—the city's famous kitchen market, operating for over 190 years—is extraordinary for a morning hour. Fresh seafood, vegetables, prepared food to eat while you walk, street-stall chefs in full whites cooking directly in front of you. We ate the best oysters of our lives here, at 10 a.m., for an amount of money that seemed implausibly small.

Nara & the Deer

Day trip from Kyoto or Osaka: **Nara**, the ancient capital before Kyoto. Famous for **Tōdai-ji Temple**—the largest wooden building in the world, housing a 15-meter bronze Buddha—and, perhaps more famous still, for the deer. Nara has approximately 1,200 *sika* deer that wander freely through the park and streets of the old city. They are technically considered messengers of the gods. They are, in practice, extremely pushy about crackers. We bought crackers. They found us before we could find them. One ate part of Harshit's pocket. No refunds from divine deer.

Japan Highlights — Our Picks

- **Shibuya Scramble Crossing**: Watch from the observation deck.
- **Fushimi Inari**: Arrive at 6:30 a.m. to beat the crowds.
- **Arashiyama Bamboo Grove**: Another early-morning job.
- **Philosopher's Path**: Kyoto canal walk, best in spring.
- **Dotonbori Night Walk**: Osaka street food at its peak.
- **Kuromon Ichiba Market**: Morning seafood and fresh produce.
- **Tōdai-ji Temple, Nara**: World's largest wooden building.
- **Hiroshima Peace Memorial**: Sobering and essential.

Tokyo: Mario, Mt. Fuji & the Beautiful, Ordered Chaos of Japan's Capital

You don't ease into Tokyo. You land, you blink, and you're already in love. Over seven days — across two stints split by the rest of Japan — this city handed us bullet-train mornings, neon-soaked nights, a near-religious view of **Mt. Fuji**, the best vegan ramen of our lives, the funniest convenience-store payment incident of our lives — the kind of story we still laugh about in our sleep, but can never quite do justice to in words — and the quiet revelation that a megacity can also be the most ordered place on earth. This is the full diary, from the Mario waving at us in arrivals to a matcha latte at Lawson that turned into an inside joke we'll be telling for years.

Day 1: 17th April

Mario, Ginza & the One-Drink Rule

Tokyo introduces itself the way only Tokyo can — with **cleanliness**, **order inside a crowd**, an impossible skyline, and a giant **Mario** waving at us before we'd even cleared customs. After a small dance with route maps and our brand-new **Suica cards**, we made our way to **Hostel Wasabi in Asakusa**, and somewhere between the metro and the front door realised we were staying a stone's throw from **Senso-ji** — a happy accident we'd keep rediscovering all week.

Check-in wasn't until 3pm. We briefly toyed with jumping straight onto the **Gotemba Premium Outlets** for shoes — three hundred brands at 2.5 hours from Tokyo, the kind of place where Nike, Onitsuka and Asics dreams come true — but it was already too late in the day. Plan B: **clothes shopping in Ginza**. Brand prices barely shift between Tokyo neighbourhoods, so the flagship strip wins by default, and **Uniqlo** and **GU** sat firmly at the top of the list. We ate first, at a vegan café called **2foods**, where we split a burger, a smoothie and a Coke, and then walked over to GU, picking up the **On Shoes** flagship as an unplanned addition to Harshit's mental list along the way. GU was full of clothes we wanted at prices we could actually justify. We promised ourselves Uniqlo too, but by the time we reached its hell-crowded entrance it was 4pm, our long-flight hangover had kicked in, and we surrendered. A taxi back to the hostel, a quick check-in, and out cold.

The hostel was exactly as promised: spotless. **Harshit got the lower bunk, I got the upper**. Two hours of nap and I wanted more — but I forced myself up and shook him awake too, because if we let the jet lag win at 6pm we'd be wide-eyed at 3am. We stepped back out into Asakusa and did one full loop of GU at **Rox Mall** — three solid hours of shopping in which we will, very deliberately, not be itemising the billing amounts ■. We strolled past the famous **Donki** without going in (it deserves its own day), and on the way back Harshit spotted a tiny vegan Japanese restaurant called **Fujifuku**.

Fujifuku ran on a **one-meal, one-drink-per-person** rule — apparently common in Japan, but as Indians used to ordering for the whole table, it felt very odd at first ■. The restaurant is run by a single owner-chef who personally walks you through every dish in the set course, and by the end of it the oddness was gone and the meal had quietly become one of the warmest of the trip. Back at the hostel we opened our laptops and booked the **Willer Bus to Mt. Fuji** for the 19th — leaving from **Shibuya**, with Harshit having done the visibility research the way only Harshit does. The 18th would be Asakusa and **Kappabashi Street**. Plans set, alarms set, bunks claimed. We slept like babies.

Snapshots from Day 1

Day 2: 18th April

Kappabashi & the Akihabara Vortex

Sweet wind, mild sun — the kind of Tokyo morning that asks you to slow down. We sorted outfits for today *and* tomorrow in one go because the bunk room was tight, late-night wardrobe negotiations were impossible ■, and tomorrow was Mt. Fuji — the highlight of highlights, deserving its own clothes. On this trip I'd already decided: no rushing. Sleep properly, wander properly. We were ready by noon — and only by noon.

Harshit had found a nearby vegan café for pizza and pastries to start the day, and from there we drifted into **Kappabashi**, the kitchen street. If you live for ceramics and Japanese knives, it is heaven; for me it was a thirty-minute walk-through where the craftsmanship was undeniable but the prices were not gentle on a traveller's wallet, and we walked out empty-handed.

By 2pm we were in **Akihabara**. The local hubs, I'd told Harshit, were **BIC Camera** and **Yodobashi** — we'd check BIC first, Yodobashi second. Reader, you need *days* for those two stores. We walked into BIC at 3pm and walked out at 7pm, with Harshit gently complaining the whole way down that I hadn't let him stroll properly and had vetoed half the things he wanted to take home. Eight to twelve floors of electronics, toys, video games, watches, and entire categories of object we didn't know existed. Wallets lighter, hearts heavier. Second round of shopping done.

Tired and hungry, we hunted for vegan food in the area and the only viable option turned out to be an **Indian restaurant inside Yodobashi**. Mid-thali, I made an executive decision: *Harshit does not get to re-enter Yodobashi*. After BIC, I knew he would buy every single electronic item in that building. Akihabara at night is *lit* — every Tokyo neighbourhood has its own story, and this one shouts it. Early bus tomorrow. Back to the hostel.

Snapshots from Day 2

Every area in Tokyo tells a different story. Asakusa whispers of old temples and street snacks. Akihabara screams in neon. Shibuya crosses every culture at once. And somehow the city holds it all together in perfect, ordered coexistence.

Day 3: 19th April The Mt. Fuji Day

Up early for the highway bus. We pulled out the new clothes saved for this exact day — Fuji deserved its own outfit. We swung by the **Lawson** outside the hostel, did a small translation dance with the snack packaging, and ended up on the bus with seats *not* next to each other — the last-minute booking penalty. The early start did come with one unexpected gift, though: at **7:30am**, **Senso-ji had no crowd**. After two days of failing to visit a temple twenty steps from our hostel, we finally saw it the way you're meant to — quiet, almost empty. We rode on through Shibuya, exited via the **Hachiko statue** for a quick photo, and headed for the bus pickup.

The pickup was on a very narrow street that absolutely did not look like a bus terminal. We circled, confused, until Harshit reread the email and found the magic line: *5th floor of the mall*. It took us a beat to absorb that highway buses leave from the fifth floor of a shopping mall, and another beat to find the lift. We made it with ten minutes to spare.

Seats apart, snacks in hand. The bus had free WiFi, but between the comfort of the Willer seats and our 4am alarm, I gave in to a long, easy nap. Harshit woke me up just before arrival to a window full of **Mt. Fuji** — and yes, every bit of the hype is earned. We rolled past Gotemba and pulled into **Kawaguchiko station**. On the way in, I'd booked the **Fuji Bus** ticket that loops around the five lakes — four routes, with the **red route** the most famous for its Fujisan views.

At the station, the red bus had a monster queue and the **green route** bus was sitting right there with its doors open, so we jumped on. The green loop was lovely, but Harshit kept feeling we were wasting

time — he wanted Fuji properly framed, not glimpsed. After the green loop, he Googled the best viewpoints and we walked toward **Lake Kawaguchiko** — and Fuji was nowhere to be seen. The red bus eventually rescued us. We got off at **Oishi Park**, finally took the photos that justified the entire trip, ate the famous **ice cream**, and bought a box of **cookies**.

We told ourselves we'd skip **Chureito Pagoda** in favour of chilling. We caught the red bus once more, got off at a spot where **sakura and Fuji** framed each other perfectly, took another round of photos, and rolled back into Kawaguchiko around 3pm — three hours till the bus home. And then, in classic us fashion, we took the shot. We bought a separate train ticket, raced to Chureito, climbed the entire pagoda, got the postcard view, ran back down, and made it to the Willer bus with not a minute to spare.

At the station, I noticed someone collecting **stamps** — and realised I hadn't picked one up in two whole days. That little discovery kicked off my **stamp quest** for the rest of the trip. The Willer bus dropped us at **Akihabara** and the dinner hunt began. I refused another Indian meal. By 9pm, most kitchens in Tokyo close, but we found **Afuri** and had our first proper ramen in Japan. I used a fork; Harshit handled chopsticks like a pro — he adapts effortlessly to these things. We finished slowly, equal parts tired and satisfied, replayed the day's wrong-bus, right-bus and sprint-to-the-pagoda detours one more time, and made the contented walk back to the hostel.

Snapshots from Day 3 — Mt. Fuji

Day 4: 20th April Shibuya, Shinjuku & Harajuku

Today belonged to the famous trio: **Shibuya, Shinjuku, Harajuku**. We began at **Meiji Shrine**. Beyond its religious significance, the wonder of the place is that it sits inside a *forest* in the heart of Tokyo — a forest, in a megacity. Wine barrels lining the path, the oldest wooden Torii gate, and a hush that simply shouldn't exist this close to Shibuya.

In Japan you learn coexistence in the real sense — of human and nature, of modernity and cultural roots, of skyscrapers and shrines. Order inside chaos.

From the forest, we walked into the world-famous **Shibuya crossing**. We did the tourist ritual properly: crossed it over and over, shot videos from every angle, then went up for the free upper view from a mall. Lunch was at **Falafel Brothers** inside Parco. People will tell you vegetarian and vegan food is hard to find in Japan — it isn't, it's just slightly pricier, and that's the cost of travel. Mid-meal, we discovered Parco had a **Pokémon Center and a Nintendo store** one floor down. The craziness for those two on a packed weekday afternoon has to be seen to be believed.

Snapshots from Day 4 — Meiji Shrine & Shibuya Crossing

Then the great Shibuya shop-hop — **Asics, ABC Mart, Shibuya 109, 2nd Street** — and from there we drifted into **Harajuku's Takeshita Street** for snacks and boba tea, soaking in the loud, sticker-sweet teenage energy that gives the street its name.

Evening was **Shinjuku** — neon lights, the cat billboard, the Godzilla head, and slow walks down **Omoide Yokocho** (Memory Lane) and **Golden Gai**. We couldn't find anything for us to eat in those tiny lanes, but the vibe alone was worth the detour: narrow alleys packed with people and tiny izakayas. It reminded us a little of **Paratha Gali in Chandni Chowk, Delhi** — except, well, much cleaner and much quieter. Even Tokyo's busiest streets don't *feel* noisy.

Dinner plan: **T's TanTan**, the famous vegan ramen counter at Tokyo Station. Getting there is its own quest. We pulled into Tokyo Station at 7:30pm and only reached the restaurant at 8:30pm — despite it

being inside the station. **Tokyo Station is a literal maze**: not just a station, but underground streets for food, groceries, restaurants, shopping — every other big-city station we've ever known feels small in comparison. We got lost. A nearby restaurant owner heard us mangle the name; his English was limited, so he found someone else, walked them over, and that person personally led us not just to the restaurant but to the right queue line, so we wouldn't get lost again. People go out of their way for you in Japan, and you never forget it. The ramen, when it finally arrived, was every bit worth the maze — gyoza first, then steaming bowls of TanTan, eaten slowly because our legs were begging us to. We hobbled out happier than we had any right to be after walking three neighbourhoods in a single day, and rode the metro home half-asleep.

Snapshots from Day 4 — Shibuya shop-hop, Harajuku, Shinjuku & T's TanTan

Day 5: 21st April

Asakusa Snacks, Jimbocho Books & the Overnight Bus

Vacating day. The overnight bus to **Kyoto** was at **9:40pm**, and the hostel agreed to hold our luggage for free until 6:30pm, with **1,000 yen per half hour** after that. We packed up everything we'd accumulated (a lot), did the formalities by noon, and stepped into a breezy, slightly cloudy Tokyo morning.

We'd lived in Asakusa for four full days and barely seen it, so today the plan was the **Asakusa market** and the much-anticipated **Jimbocho**, Tokyo's books district. The Asakusa market is enormous, and we worked our way through every snack on the list — **daifuku**, **baby castella cakes**, **matcha ice cream** — before circling back to **Senso-ji** for a round of photos, this time with the crowds it deserves.

Jimbocho was both magical and humbling. So many books — almost all of them in Japanese. We hunted down the stores with English translations while Harshit researched titles for me, and with the options that thin, I almost walked out empty-handed. We were already discussing giving up Jimbocho and trying one more bookstore in **Ginza**, plus the famous stationery temple **Itoya**. And then, just as we were leaving Jimbocho, I spotted a shelf of **physics books**, and on it — **Kreyszig**. I cannot put that feeling into words. To find, on a side street in Tokyo, the very textbook that walked me through my **BSc Honours Physics** years in India. It is surreal that some concepts get learned worldwide from the same author. I stood there for a long minute, just grinning.

At Ginza, we ate at **Ain Soph** and quietly abandoned the Itoya plan. Then more **GU** — yes, again. Shopping had become our quiet daily ritual on this trip; not a single day went by without something landing in a bag, and Ginza GU on a weekday afternoon was just too good to walk past. From there we wandered into a **Daiso**, the kind of stop that turns a quick browse into an hour. We came out with stationery for both of us, snack souvenirs for back home, a couple of household oddities we didn't know we needed until we saw them, and a few small gifts for family. On the walk back, we passed **Sanseido**, a big publishing-house bookstore. Harshit talked me into finally buying — and I am quietly grateful for the way he does that, the same way he'd convinced me to grab the DIY kits at BIC Camera. I walked out with **Klara and the Sun** and **Butter**. Books I will cherish forever.

Back to the hostel by 6pm-ish, paid for the extra half hour, and packed. Two suitcases, one backpack — we had flown into Japan with the empty **black suitcase nested inside the red one** to save baggage on the way in, and we'd been quietly piling every shopping bag into it as the days went by. Now that they finally had to come out as two separate bags, the bill of all that shopping became suddenly, physically real — both of them were *heavy*. Bus and metro to the bus terminal. The bus dropped us right outside the metro station, but the platform was up a flight of stairs. With bags this heavy, we spotted a lift across the road, crossed over, took the lift up — and discovered we were on the wrong platform, with no internal exit. So now we had to climb stairs, walk across, and climb stairs

back down. *Some shortcuts lead to long cuts.* ■

Snapshots from Day 5 — Asakusa market, Jimbocho & Ginza

■ Tokyo Overnight-Bus Tips (Willer)

- **Hostel luggage hold** is usually free till early evening — confirm cutoff or you'll pay by the half hour.
- **Willer > Flix on comfort** — but seat partitions only really work if you're travelling solo.
- **Stock dinner first.** Eateries near bus terminals fill fast; a 7-Eleven run is the dependable backup.
- **Plan station lifts in advance** — crossing the road for an accessible platform can land you on the wrong line.

We reached the terminal with 45 minutes to spare. **Bombay Sizzler** nearby had a long wait, so we grabbed a few things from 7-Eleven instead. First-ever **Willer Bus**: seats directly behind the driver. Verdict — definitely better than Flix, but the seat partitions are only really useful if you're travelling solo. Snacks down, eyes closed, Kyoto in the morning.

Must-Do in Tokyo (the first 5 days)

- **Senso-ji at 7:30am:** Before the tourist tide arrives.
- **Mt. Fuji Day Trip:** Book Willer Bus from Shibuya — totally worth it.
- **Shibuya Crossing:** Cross it multiple times. Get the upper view.
- **Akihabara:** BIC Camera + Yodobashi — budget your time wisely!
- **Meiji Shrine & Forest:** A forest inside a megacity is surreal.
- **Shinjuku at Night:** Neon lights, Golden Gai, Omoide Yokocho.
- **Kappabashi Kitchen Street:** Knife enthusiasts will go crazy.
- **T's TanTan at Tokyo Station:** Best vegan ramen — Google Maps it first.
- **Jimbocho:** Heaven if you read — bring patience for the Japanese-only shelves.
- **Fujifuku, Asakusa:** A single owner-chef, a set course, an evening you won't forget.

Day 6: 28th April

Back in Tokyo — Hotel, Komeda, Pizza in Bed

Tokyo Station: still a maze. We worked out the route to our hotel — **Almont Inn** — and rolled in way before check-in. They held our luggage. We finished off whatever was still hanging around in our Lawson and supermarket bags from the overnight bus, and because we still weren't sleepy, did what one does in Ginza on a weekday afternoon: more **Uniqlo shopping**. The store wasn't crowded — the perfect window — and we picked things for us and a few for family. (You go to Ginza, you come back carrying bags. It's a law.)

By midday we were properly hungry. The veg-burger hunt failed at three different shops in a row, until Harshit pulled another rabbit out of his café-research hat: **Komeda's Café — Plant-Based Kissa**. The food was excellent, the drinks even better, and by the time we walked out, the overnight bus from Hiroshima had finally caught up with us. We dragged ourselves to the hotel by 4pm, checked in, and slept off the rest of the afternoon.

We had a **7:20am flight to Sapporo** the next morning, so this stop was always going to be a quick pit-stop — wake up around 7pm, no appetite for stepping back out, order **pizza on Uber Eats**, pack one backpack for Sapporo and leave the rest in the suitcases. The hotel agreed to hold them for the two days we'd be away, since we'd be back to the same room. Then sleep, again.

Snapshots from Day 6 — Tokyo Station, Komeda's & Almont Inn

Day 7: 1st May

The Final Day, the Rain & the Lawson Incident

Last day of the trip. The plan: fly back from Sapporo, push on to **Yokohama**. We were up at 4am in **Sapporo**, on the **Limousine Bus** to **New Chitose Airport**. At the gate they announced heavy rain in Tokyo and offered to reschedule. We didn't. The plane was nearly empty so I claimed three seats and slept across them. Tokyo was a wall of rain when we landed — safe, but soaked. Yokohama got quietly binned.

So what now in Tokyo? We hadn't tried **okonomiyaki** yet, and a quick search threw up options in Ginza and Asakusa. Asakusa won — there was always more to eat and see there, and we'd started this trip in Asakusa too. We worked our way through okonomiyaki at a small Asakusa spot whose name I have already forgotten (the food, I haven't), our first careful sips of **plum wine**, and another wander through the market, and then we surrendered to a small matcha pilgrimage: a **parfait** at **The Matcha House**, tea at **Hatoya Matcha**, and a **matcha ice cream** at **Maccha House** — the purest form of matcha we tasted anywhere in Japan. One last round of skincare shopping between **OS Drug** and **Matsumoto Kiyoshi**, and then back to **Senso-ji** for the final time. This time, we played the **omikuji** — the paper fortune game. Asakusa to Asakusa. The trip closed itself off neatly.

Back at the hotel, suitcases reunited, the rain still drumming against the windows. For dinner we wanted one of the famous pizza places we'd been saving, but Friday night in Tokyo had every single one of them full. We pivoted to an Italian spot — **OBICÀ** — tucked into one of those polished, lantern-lit Tokyo streets that come alive on a Friday night, lined with quietly buzzing wine bars, izakayas, and small restaurants spilling laughter onto the pavement. Exactly the kind of pocket of the city you'd want to spend a date night in. We dressed up for it. I always pack one dress for date night and almost never use it, but Harshit pumps me up for these things. The place was lovely, the food was excellent, the **tiramisu** was unreal and the drinks were great. They charged extra for cutlery, and when the owner explained it almost apologetically and we told him it's exactly the same in Italy, he lit up. He sources his olive oil directly from Italy. We talked about wanting to spend weeks in **Sicily and Tuscany** one day. We talked the whole Japan trip over and quietly realised how much of it would live in us forever.

And then — the legendary **Lawson Incident**. We had a few yen left across our Suica cards and a small pile of cash, and we wanted to spend the whole lot before flying home. Lawson takes Suica, so in we went. Harshit picked up a matcha latte. Now in his head, the plan was perfectly clear: pay from the **first Suica**, then the **second Suica**, then cash, then a fourth method if anything was still left to clear — *four* payment splits for one matcha latte. I do not think a single payment machine on this planet has been built for that combination. And I think that, apart from me, there is now exactly one other person in the world who will always remember Harshit — the cashier whose neurons he gently damaged that night.

In the cashier's head, the plan was simpler: one Suica, the rest in cash. He swiped a Suica, asked for cash — we didn't have enough. And once a Suica is swiped, *that money is gone*; you cannot reverse it, you have to complete the transaction. After much back-and-forth, the cashier **put in his own money** to close the bill, then asked Harshit to repay him from the second Suica, assuming there would be

enough on it — and we promptly got stuck in the exact same loop again. Eventually he gave up on us entirely and just pushed the latte across the counter. So then, like the deeply responsible humans we are, we tried to *buy other things we didn't even want*, just to balance the books. Even writing this now, my stomach is hurting from laughing — I doubled over outside the store and laughed until it ached. Some moments simply don't translate to the page; this one will live in my head forever. We walked back to the hotel still chuckling, did the final pack, weighed our suitcases on the hotel scale, and slept.

Snapshots from Day 7 — the rainy Asakusa pilgrimage, OBICÀ & the Lawson incident

Tokyo is not one city. It's many cities stacked inside each other — each neighbourhood a different world, each street a different story. It doesn't overwhelm you; it invites you. And when you leave, you already know you'll come back.

Kyoto: Matcha, Temples, Rain & Our Fifth Anniversary Together

There are some cities you visit and some cities you slow down for. Kyoto, we learned over three slow, rain-soft, matcha-soaked days, very firmly belongs to the second list. This is the diary of our fifth anniversary, a lost bus pass at the Golden Temple, two near-religious bowls of vegetarian chilli ramen, and a tiny matcha town that quietly became one of our favourite memories from Japan.

Day 1: 22nd April

Arrival & the Uji Matcha Trip

Kyoto Station at **5:30 a.m.** has the cool, unhurried hush of a city that has been awake for centuries. We dragged our cases and one over-loved backpack onto the metro and were ringing the bell at **Kiori Exec** by 6:30 a.m. — the kind of timing that earns a polite, faintly amused bow from a hotel receptionist. Check-in wasn't until much later, but the staff promised to flag us the moment a room came free.

For us, walking into that lobby felt like turning a page. The shared-room, shared-bathroom, hostel-budget chapter of Japan was officially behind us. From here on: our own door, our own kettle, our own quiet.

The day's plan was simple — **Uji**, the matcha town nearly an hour from Kyoto. But nothing opened before 9:30 a.m., and our temple-tank was still full from Senso-ji in Tokyo. So I did the one thing I'm consistently brilliant at when tired: I sketched out a Uji walking map on my phone, then promptly fell asleep on a lobby sofa.

■ Kyoto Hotel Tip — Kiori Exec

Arriving at sunrise? Kiori Exec's lobby is comfortable enough to nap in, the staff are unusually kind to early arrivals, and they actually *do* bump you into a room early if one's clean. Worth the small premium over a hostel after a long Shinkansen day.

The room came through at 10 a.m. We crashed again, properly this time. By the time we surfaced and made it to Uji, it was **4:30 p.m.** — a late, late start. We'd starred a long list of matcha shops on Google Maps and got to exactly *two*; most close at 5:30 or 6 p.m. Two was enough to fall completely in love.

Our first proper **matcha parfait** — thick whisked matcha layered with adzuki beans, soft jelly, soft-serve, and one ceremoniously placed dango. **Matcha tea** served the right way: bitter, grassy, alive. **Matcha candies** that somehow taste like the leaf itself. We stocked up for home — tea, latte powder, candies, even **matcha soba noodles**. Matcha is one of those flavours that grows on you with every sip, every spoonful, until ordinary green tea feels like a faint photocopy.

With the shutters down, we did what Uji rewards most: we wandered. The river. **Uji Shrine** in its early-evening quiet. A neighbourhood supermarket that doubled as a small adventure. The bronze statues from *The Tale of Genji*, standing where one of the world's oldest novels was set a thousand years ago.

By 8 p.m. we were back in Kyoto and inside **Vegan Izakaya**, where the staff first told us — kindly, regretfully — that they were fully booked. One soft *please* from us, a soft pause from them, and a small table appeared.

Their **gyoza** turned out to be the best of our entire Japan trip — thin-skinned, crisp-bottomed, herby and juicy in the middle. The **sake** landed on legs that had nothing left in them. We walked back to the

hotel anyway, the way you do when you're happy and a little drunk and the city is too pretty to call a cab.

Before sleep, a small piece of admin. Suica was costing us **320 yen per ride**, and tomorrow's big day would have at least four bus hops on it. I switched us to a **Day Bus Pass** — break-even at four rides, profit at five. Map sorted. Lights out.

Five years... half a decade with Golu. It still feels new, it still feels fresh, and it still is a very happy place. He makes it.

Day 2: 23rd April

Our Anniversary, in the Rain

Five years. I still can't believe half a decade has passed with Golu. It feels new, it still feels fresh, and it is — quietly, daily — a very happy place. He makes it.

People will tell you the spark fades, that you grow used to each other. I disagree. He still irritates me. I am still completely incapable of his cleanliness and his discipline, and he is somehow the steady ground to my live-wire chaos. We've been to many countries together, made highs and blunders along the way; as long as we're together, I have the energy to make any of it right. No matter how the world chooses to see me, he has seen the worst of me and still chooses to stay. That is luck, and I do not take it lightly.

We pulled on the new clothes we'd been saving for the day and picked up our transport tickets. The famous Kyoto breeze did a polite warm-up — and the moment we stepped outside, the sky opened. Two hotel-borrowed umbrellas held the entire day together; it rained *hard*.

First stop: **Kiyomizu-dera**, perched on its wooden stilts over a hillside of cedar and maple. The Japanese way of building a temple is so different from what we grew up around in India — quieter, more orderly, almost shy in its grandeur. Below the temple, the two iconic streets — **Sannenzaka and Ninenzaka** — twist downhill in old wood and stone. We tried local sweets, ate a warm apple pie, ducked into a **Starbucks** (yes — and even Starbucks here is different, with low Japanese-style floor seating). Coffees down, we plotted the next move. **Kinkaku-ji**, the Golden Temple, won the vote.

I was lost in the gold for a full minute before I realised I'd **lost my day bus pass**. You can't go back out through the entrance at Kinkaku-ji once you're in, but a kind guard checked anyway. Nothing. I felt awful. And then Harshit's classic patient positivity stepped in — we'd already gotten three rides out of it, we were fine. Even writing this now, it still nags at me a little. But it is okay, as long as we're together ■.

■ Kyoto in the Rain — Our Cheat Sheet

- **Borrow umbrellas from your hotel** — almost every Kyoto hotel keeps a stand by the door.
- **Covered markets are everything.** Nishiki, Shinkyogoku, Teramachi — hours of strolling without a drop on you.
- **Temples are better in the rain.** Fewer crowds, softer light, glossier roofs. Kinkaku-ji especially.
- **Skip the kimono day if it's raining hard** — they pull beautifully, but not in puddles.

Kyoto's covered markets are an underrated travel hack. The rain literally doesn't touch you; you drift from shop to shop for hours. We did a full sweep of **3 Coins** — hairbrush, foldable chair, the works — and then a two-floor bookstore inside a mall that quietly knocked the wind out of me. The reading culture in Japan is real; the love for their own language even more so. Across both floors, exactly one

shelf held English translations. Every time I walk into a bookstore I feel quietly small — there is just so much left to read.

The rain finally ruled out Fushimi Inari for the day. We circled back to the market, and that's when I spotted — half by accident, half by destiny — an Indian restaurant. On a rainy anniversary, the heart wants comfort food. **Delhi Restaurant, Kyoto: chole bhature, onion parantha**, run by a Dehradun-wala for the last 20 years. I would not have planned this anniversary any differently than to watch the look on Harshit's face after a plate of Indian food on the other side of the world.

I have a thousand things racing through my head at any moment; he is calm and sweet, and his quietest joy still lives in food that tastes like home. I feel lucky to come from a populated ethnicity — his comfort, I can find for him almost anywhere in the world ■.

I would not have planned this anniversary any differently than to watch the look on Harshit's face after a plate of chole bhature on the other side of the world.

Day 3: 24th April

Torii Gates, Ramen, & the Long Walk Home

The famous **Fushimi Inari** day, and our last in Kyoto. We've been slow-paced this entire trip and today's wake-up made no apologies for it: brunch at noon. We chose **Ain Soph Kyoto** — we'd already fallen for Ain Soph Ginza in Tokyo and this branch held the line beautifully. Then, because matcha had us in its grip, we walked to **MACCHA HOUSE (■■■■)** for a parfait. Wow. Simply wow. We added the seasonal **matcha-strawberry-sakura latte** and that, too, was outstanding — bright, faintly floral, the strawberry doing exactly enough.

Heavy brunch behind us, Golu was set on the hike. We had talked about doing the traditional **kimono** rental — I'd originally planned it for the anniversary; the rain killed that — and decided, with very little debate, that the money was better spent on a second matcha parfait ■.

We reached **Fushimi Inari Taisha** at **1:15 p.m.** and started up. Walking through those endless vermilion **Torii gates** hits in a way you can't quite put into words. You don't need to read the kanji on each one for the place to get under your skin. We climbed to a clearing where the city opens up beneath you. On the way down I outpaced Harshit, who got mildly annoyed by my speed. He was back to normal by the time we reached the foot of the mountain. More photos, more watching strangers pray, more watching them tie wishes onto small wooden boards.

The market around Fushimi Inari is mostly non-veg, so we headed back to central Kyoto for round two of shopping: **skincare**. After enough late-night research, I'd locked in on **OS Drugstore** as the best price-point store, with **Matsumoto Kiyoshi** as the comparison. We bounced between the two for the best deals — plus Japanese gums, plus jellies, plus too many labels in too many translations.

■ Kyoto Skincare Shopping — How We Saved

- **Compare 2 stores minimum.** Same product can differ 20–30% between OS Drugstore and Matsumoto Kiyoshi a block apart.
- **OS Drugstore** tends to win on serums & lotions; **Matsumoto Kiyoshi** wins on sheet masks & sunscreens.
- **Carry your passport** — both chains offer tax-free over ¥5,000.
- **Snack aisle = souvenir gold.** Konjac jellies, melon gums, sakura KitKats. Don't be us — buy the 14-flavour pack.

Dinner was the very famous **Kyoto Engine**. One absolute MUST EAT. We finished two bowls of ramen in no time. **The best ramen we have ever had** — full stop. I crave it just writing this. Who would have imagined the highlight of a Japanese trip would be a **vegetarian chilli ramen**? Naturally a parfait followed for dessert; Kyoto Engine had what felt like a thousand varieties on the display board. With so much sugar in our blood and rain in our shoes, we walked back to the hotel to enjoy our last Kyoto night. Then came the pack: route to Osaka figured out, two suitcases and a fully-packed backpack lined up by the door.

Kyoto teaches you to slow down — not because you have to, but because the city refuses to be rushed. Even the rain in Kyoto walks.

Where It All Happened

Three days, one ancient capital, a lot of rain and a lot of matcha. Pan the map, click a pin — each one is a moment above.

Must-Do in Kyoto

- **Uji Matcha Town:** Go early — most shops shut by 6 p.m.
- **Kiyomizu-dera & Sannenzaka:** Best in the soft morning light.
- **Kinkaku-ji:** Even better in the rain.
- **Fushimi Inari Hike:** Walk at least to the first viewpoint.
- **Vegan Izakaya:** The gyoza — don't miss it.
- **Kyoto Engine Ramen:** The best veg ramen we've ever had.
- **Covered Market Strolling:** Rain or shine, a delight.
- **Day Bus Pass:** Worth it from 4+ rides — *don't lose it.*

Osaka: Six Pairs of Shoes, a Castle & Dotonbori in the Rain

Day 1: 25th April

Rinku Premium Outlet & Rikuro's Cheesecake

The most awaited day. We were in Osaka for two days, but day one was reserved for one thing only — **Rinku Premium Outlet**. Finally, the long wait for shoe shopping would be over. Osaka is barely **1 hour 15 minutes from Kyoto**, so we reached our hotel — **Garner Hotel** — by **11:30 a.m.** Signing up to their loyalty program got us a free early check-in and two complimentary water bottles. We dumped the bags, grabbed a quick brunch nearby, and made it to Rinku by **2:30 p.m.**

I'll be honest — writing this on **18 May**, I still can't quite believe what happened next. On the 25th of April, I did not imagine in my wildest dreams that we would end up walking out of Japan with **six pairs of shoes**. But Japan grows on you. With so many options, someone like me only gets more and more confused.

Rinku sits just outside Osaka, near Kansai airport. It's open-air, breezy, and houses **250 shops** — every international brand at outlet pricing, then tax-free on top, and since we were there during **Golden Week**, we were quietly hoping for one more layer of discount. They hand out proper guided maps and have staff to point you in the right direction; seeing it all in one day is practically impossible.

We started with shoes — **ASICS, Onitsuka Tiger, Nike, Sketchers**. So many options. After trying half the wall at Nike, the numbers started to feel surreal: shoes that retail for **■10,000+ in India were sitting at ■4,000–6,000**. We bought **three pairs from Nike**. Nike isn't a tax-free shop, so technically we wouldn't get the extra 10% off — but the upside is you can wear them in Japan straight away. Then at the billing counter I noticed new members get a 10% discount anyway. Signed up on the spot. **Very happy.**

Next was Sketchers. We didn't end up buying for ourselves, but picked up **two pairs for our parents**. That's five pairs in a row — never have we shopped like this — so we forced ourselves to stop. ASICS and Onitsuka, honestly, didn't feel worth it compared to what Nike and Sketchers were offering that day.

Then clothes. By 6 p.m., either the deals weren't great or my feet had given up — possibly both. Rinku also has a **KitKat store** with a unique **14-flavour collection gift pack**. I thought it was expensive and walked away. **I regret it now.** It was absolutely worth taking. Lesson learned: in Japan, if a KitKat gift box catches your eye, just buy it.

Right next to the outlet is a giant **Ferris wheel** and a beach. We were tired and hungry, so we skipped both and headed back to central Osaka. Then a small mission: get the famous **Rikuro's Cheesecake** from **Daimaru Mall**. It closes at 8 p.m. We reached at **7:45 p.m.** Made it. Worth the hype — and we picked up one other thing in the same store that was equally good.

Dinner was ramen. Honestly, by the time we sat down, I was so exhausted from carrying shoes and walking that I couldn't enjoy it. Didn't even finish. Took the bus back, ate the cheesecake in bed, and crashed.

Day 2: 26th April

Osaka Castle, Don Quijote & Dotonbori

Somehow I'd convinced myself that **Matsumoto Kiyoshi** didn't carry KitKats — I hadn't spotted any in Kyoto — and obviously I wanted the full **Don Quijote** experience anyway. After some research I figured out that the Don Quijote branches in Osaka offer the best rates for bulk buying. So if you've been following from day one, you can guess exactly which direction day two was pointed in. ■

We started at **Osaka Castle**. It's genuinely impressive — gold detailing catching the sun, stone walls and moats holding centuries of history. We clicked far too many pictures. Since it was a **Sunday**, families had spread out picnic setups across the gardens outside. It felt so good to watch. We didn't grow up in that culture, and we've only seen it in movies — seeing the picnic culture live made me realise how much we miss going out into nature on holidays back home, partly because Pune doesn't really have spaces like that.

After the castle, we headed for lunch — but the spot we'd picked near Donki was closed because of Sunday. We found a **Nepalese restaurant** nearby and ate **Indian roti and sabzi**. Reset complete.

And then, finally — the other most-awaited stop. **Don Quijote**. It has everything. Literally everything. Every snack, every chocolate, every skincare item we'd been buying piecemeal across Japan — all under one roof. Just slightly pricier on individual items. The bits I was happiest about were the **skincare from OS Drug Store and Matsumoto Kiyoshi**, then chocolates, candies, gums, **matcha lattes**, and more KitKats than I'd like to admit. We spent **3.5 hours** in there, and I'm convinced no amount of time is enough — it just depends on how long you can keep going.

By the end the bag was too heavy to drag anywhere else, so we went back to the hotel to drop it. And of course, that's when it started raining.

We still wanted to see **Dotonbori**, but I knew the veg options there would be limited. Harshit found **Mercy Vegan Cafe** — a small spot near Dotonbori run by a lady and her daughter. Vegan, cosy, warm. The food was great. The desserts and baked cookies were great too. If you're strictly vegetarian, I'd recommend eating something proper before heading into Dotonbori itself.

From there, we walked to **Dotonbori**. The vibe is unparalleled, even in the rain. We did the obligatory tourist photos in front of **Don Quijote** and the **Glico running man**, and wandered both sides of the canal.

Then came the shock. I spotted KitKats at a Matsumoto Kiyoshi on Dotonbori for **220 yen** per packet — I had paid **400 yen** for the same packet earlier. Worse: in that one lane there were **five Matsumoto Kiyoshi stores** and every single one had a different price for the same KitKat, ranging from **220 to 350 yen**. It's a tough game. But like Harshit reminded me — it is what it is. We stayed until our feet gave up — usually it's the shop closing time that wins, this time it was the feet.

Tokyo is order. Kyoto is calm. Osaka is the friend who pulls you into the night with shopping bags and street food, and laughs the loudest. You don't visit Osaka — you hang out with it.

A quick warning about Garner Hotel

Garner has **five hotels inside a 3 km radius** in central Osaka. Put the exact location into Maps when you head back, otherwise you'll walk to the wrong one, realise mid-lobby, and have to walk back to the right one. Ask me how I know.

Packing for the Shinkansen

Tomorrow's a big day — bullet train + **Hiroshima**. Time to pack. After all this shopping, the black suitcase had to come out from inside the red one. Final count: **one large, one medium, one small suitcase, and one fully-packed backpack**. We've pre-booked the **extra-space seats on the Shinkansen** specifically to handle this much luggage. Early morning train. Sleep got delayed because of the packing, but that's fine.

Where It All Happened

Two days, one city, a lot of walking. Pan the map, click a pin — each one is a moment above.

Must-Do in Osaka

- **Rinku Premium Outlet:** 250 shops, best shoe shopping in Japan. Plan a full day.
- **Osaka Castle Grounds:** Walk the gardens, especially on a Sunday for picnic vibes.
- **Rikuro's Cheesecake (Daimaru):** Reach before 8 p.m. closing — worth the rush.
- **Don Quijote (Osaka branch):** Best bulk pricing in Japan. Block out 3+ hours.
- **Dotonbori at Night:** Glico man, Don Quijote ferris wheel, canal reflections.
- **Mercy Vegan Cafe:** Plant-based, cosy, near Dotonbori — perfect veg backup.
- **KitKat 14-Flavour Gift Pack:** Buy it. We didn't. Don't be us.
- **Check Matsumoto Kiyoshi prices in 2-3 stores** before bulk buying — same product, very different prices.

Hiroshima: A Quiet Reckoning & a City That Rebuilt Itself

Day 1: 27th April

Shinkansen, A-Bomb Dome & the Peace Museum

The 7:50 a.m. Shinkansen & the Onigiri Hunt

Our bullet train was at **7:50 a.m.**, which meant lugging two suitcases and a backpack out of the hotel a little after 6. **Osaka Station**, like every big Japanese station, is a place you could play hide-and-seek in for an afternoon and still lose. Bewilderingly large, beautifully signposted, but somehow always one corridor more than you expect.

A small moment that stuck with me: I'd entered the wrong gate trying to collect a station stamp, and the staff let me *exit through one gate and re-enter through another*, just so I could get my stamp. No fuss, no fine, just a quiet smile and a wave-through. Japan's customer service stops being remarkable only because it keeps happening, everywhere, all the time.

After three different stores and a small symphony of Google Translate, I finally tracked down **vegetarian onigiri** and a handful of snacks for the train. Then we boarded.

The Shinkansen is its own quiet miracle. Wide seats, no sound, snack trolleys that glide through like they're on ice. I've napped on a hundred trains in my life — this felt like falling asleep on a reclining sofa at home. Harshit had to wake me when we pulled in.

Arriving in Hiroshima · Lockers, Day Pass & the Red Loop Bus

We rolled into **Hiroshima** a little before 10. Bags into the station locker, **Hiroshima day pass** in hand, and a plan: cover the **A-Bomb Dome** and **Peace Memorial Park** in the morning, then push out to **Miyajima Island** in the afternoon. Some days, though, don't go according to plan — and some days, even Google Maps decides to play along with the chaos. (Foreshadowing.)

We caught the **Hiroshima sightseeing loop bus** — the friendly red one that links the major sights — and got off at the Dome.

Standing in Front of the A-Bomb Dome

There is no easy way to write about this. The skeleton of the **Genbaku Dome** has been left exactly as it was on the morning of **August 6, 1945** — every cracked beam and exposed brick a deliberate, public refusal to forget. You can read about Hiroshima all your life. Standing in front of the building that survived the blast is something else.

Inside the Peace Memorial Museum

We crossed into **Peace Memorial Park** and spent the rest of the morning at the **museum**. There is a **3D projection sequence** that reconstructs the bombing minute by minute, and every artefact — a child's burnt tricycle, a stopped watch, a scrap of school uniform — is curated with a quiet, unflinching grace. I came out emotional. I came out thinking: *physics should be the thing that brings us peace and prosperity, not the thing that ruins lives for generations*.

We finished the museum at **1 p.m.**, hungry and a little hollowed out.

Lunch & the Miyajima Decision

The plan was Hiroshima's signature **okonomiyaki** at a famous spot near the park. The queue, predictably, was around the block. Harshit pulled up an **Indian restaurant** nearby — except "nearby" took 30 to 40 minutes of wandering to actually find. By the time we'd eaten, it was **2 p.m.**

That left a math problem. Miyajima is a 2.5-hour round trip with the floating torii at the end. Our **overnight Willer bus to Tokyo** left at **6:05 p.m.** Doing both would have meant rushing the most beautiful part. So we made the harder call: **skip Miyajima, slow down, sit with Hiroshima a little longer.** It's the one regret of the day, and the reason we'll come back.

If you only saw the rest of Hiroshima — the trams, the kids on bikes, the lemon sorbet by the lake — you'd never believe what this city has lived through. Hard work, hope, and a stubborn belief in the future. Hiroshima is a living lesson in the growth mindset.

Hondori, the Sketchers Detour & a Lemon Sorbet

The afternoon belonged to the **regular city**. We wandered **Hondori arcade**, the covered shopping street near the park, and after a long internal debate about how many shoes is too many shoes, walked out of a **Sketchers outlet** with one pair each. (I wanted three. Suitcase rules.) Then we sat by the water with **lemon sorbet**, watching the ducks drift past, letting the morning settle.

We even circled back to the loop bus just to *look* — a few more neighbourhoods rolled past the window: tram lines, riverside walks, schoolkids cycling home. I think we both dozed off for a stop or two.

The Willer Bus & a Three-Minute Cliffhanger

By **4:45 p.m.** we were back at the station. Snacks bought, bags collected from the locker, red bus boarded again towards the bus terminal. During lunch we'd noticed the mall had a **bus terminal** on one of its upper floors. We'd memorised the building. Easy.

Except: when we got off the bus, **Google Maps was pointing us at a different building in the opposite direction.** We trusted it for about three minutes, realised something was off, and pivoted — it was the same mall as our lunch spot all along. Now we were behind schedule, with two suitcases and a backpack, sprinting across a mall floor, lift up to the bus terminal level, and discovering that our specific stop was at the *far end* of the floor.

5:50 p.m. A Willer staffer pointed me in the right direction. I ran. I reached the stop at **6:02 p.m.** The bus was *already there*. They asked for my ticket; I told them my husband was right behind me with it. They said: *three more minutes and we leave*. Harshit appeared at **6:03 p.m.** We were on.

The Long Ride to Tokyo

Hiroshima → Tokyo is the **longest and most expensive** overnight route we took the whole trip, and it earned every yen. We ate the snacks we'd grabbed, picked up water at one of the highway rest stops (predictably spotless toilets, predictably efficient turnaround), and somewhere outside Okayama we both dropped off like logs. We woke up rolling into Tokyo.

Where It All Happened

One day, one city, more ground than you'd think. Pan the map, click a pin — each one is a moment above.

Must-Do in Hiroshima

Our One-Day Shortlist

- **A-Bomb Dome** · Stand in front of it. Read the plaque. Take your time.
- **Peace Memorial Museum** · The 3D projection is essential and difficult.
- **Peace Memorial Park** · Walk it slowly — every monument has a story.
- **Hiroshima Okonomiyaki** · Layered with noodles. Worth queueing for if you can.
- **Miyajima Island** · Plan a full half-day. Don't squeeze it like we did.
- **Hondori Arcade** · Covered shopping street near the park.
- **Sightseeing Loop Bus (the red one)** · The easy way to see the regular city.
- **Lakeside lemon sorbet** · After the museum, you'll need it.
- **Shinkansen station stamps** · Carry a notebook. The staff are unreasonably kind about it.

Sapporo: Late-Season Sakura, Hokkaido Ice Cream & a Day with Bears

Day 1: 29th April

The 5 a.m. Bus & Becoming "Airport People"

Our Sapporo flight was at 7:20 a.m. out of Haneda, and somewhere between booking it and surviving it, we discovered the **Airport Limousine bus** — a quietly genius service that loops the city before sunrise, picks up half-awake travellers from stops that are conveniently within walking distance of every major hotel, and delivers them, calmly, to whichever of Tokyo's two airports they're flying out of (we got Haneda; Narita gets its own bus, its own crowd, its own slower morning).

We were at our stop by 5 a.m. We were at Haneda by 6. We were *through security* by 6:10 — no bag drop, no queue theatre, no shoes being barked at. Just a quiet line, a polite nod, and a tray of complimentary slippers for anyone whose shoes had to come off. The whole thing took less time than making chai at home.

Which left us with the kind of windfall you only get at 6 a.m. in an airport you've already cleared: **time**. So we did the most touristy thing imaginable and walked into Starbucks. A **Sakura Strawberry Latte**. A **Matcha Latte**. Pink and green in our hands, like we were starring in someone else's vacation reel. We don't *do* Starbucks back home — it feels indulgent, overpriced, performative. But here, somehow, it was just... normal. Reasonably priced, even. We sipped, we people-watched, we boarded.

Landing in Hokkaido

Sapporo's **New Chitose Airport** is well outside the city, so we hopped on yet another airport bus for the **~1 hour 15 minute** ride into town. Hokkaido announces itself early: the air goes crisp, the buildings spread out, the mountains stop being far-away decoration and start hanging close. **It is its own country inside Japan** — quieter, colder, slower. And yet, as we leaned against the window, pink starting to peek out from between buildings — **sakura**. We had timed it just right. Hokkaido blooms weeks after Tokyo, so the cherry blossoms we'd already grieved in Kyoto were back, this time against a chillier sky.

Hill of the Buddha · Tadao Ando's Quiet Trick

We dropped bags at the hotel and went straight back out. The **Hill of the Buddha** is about **1.5 hours** from central Sapporo — a real commitment for a first afternoon, and worth every minute. Designed by **Tadao Ando**, it's one of those places photos genuinely do not prepare you for. You approach through a long concrete tunnel, the air gets colder, the light narrows — and then the giant Buddha statue rises slowly into view, framed by hundreds of thousands of lavender plants. The lavender wasn't in bloom yet in April, but you could feel exactly what it will look like in summer.

You don't have to believe in anything in particular for the Buddha-in-the-middle-of-a-hill to do its quiet work on you. There's a stillness up there that feels lent to you, just for the visit.

The Sakura Detour (Get Off One Stop Early)

On the bus back into town, we'd been pressing our faces to the window the entire way, watching whole streets blush pink. So we did the obvious thing: **got off one stop before ours**, just to walk it. That unplanned half-hour — chilly air, fully-bloomed sakura, no agenda — turned into the most photographed stretch of our entire Japan trip. **Chilly weather plus sakura is Sapporo's whole personality**, and it is the kind of cherry-on-cake combination Honshu can't quite give you in April.

Lunch, Pole Town & the Ice Cream That Ruined Us

Lunch was at **Holistic Bio Café Veggy Way** — gentle, plant-forward, exactly the reset our bodies needed after a 5 a.m. start. Then we descended into **Pole Town**, the underground shopping arcade that begins right inside the metro station and seems to go on forever. It is a kilometre of shops, cafés and warmth — and a maze of **impossible exits**. We turned a corner, then another, and another, and somewhere along the way we accepted we were lost. Wonderfully lost.

This is where we met **Hokkaido ice cream** for the first time, and we have not been the same since. The dairy here lives up to its mythology — the soft-serve is creamier, milkier, slightly cooler in temperature, the kind of thing you eat slowly because you already know it's a one-off. We then proceeded to ruin our appetites for actual dinner by raiding two bakeries:

- **Kintoya Bake** — perfect little baked cheese tarts, warm on top, almost custardy inside.
- **Donguri** — the legend. Tray, tongs, an overwhelming wall of options, pick-and-pay chaos. We left with a bag that was heavier than our common sense.

Park Hotel · Our First 5-Star Reality Check

Most of our trip lived in **3-star budget hotels and hostels** (with one 4-star "Kiori Exec" cameo). Sapporo was our first proper 5-star. Expectation, naturally, was sky-high. The reality was... *good*, but instructively human.

Two complimentary 400 ml water bottles for the whole stay. Everything beyond that — chargeable. **No AC** (it's Hokkaido, you're not *supposed* to need one in April). The room ran warm at night, so we cracked open the heavy blackout curtains and slept behind the thin white ones — which, given Hokkaido's *extremely* early sunrise, would become a plot point the next morning. Comfortable bed, beautiful lobby, excellent service. The lesson: in Japan, "5-star" means service and finish, not American-style amenity overload. Recalibrate your expectations and you'll love it.

The Tour That Cancelled · A Klook Story

Over dinner we decided to outsource Day 2: **Noboribetsu Hell Valley, Lake Toya, Bear Ranch, Mount Usu Ropeway** — too far-flung for Hokkaido's modest public transport to handle in a single day. We booked a **Klook** tour for 7 a.m. the next morning, at around 7 p.m. the previous night. Less than 24 hours = no cancellation possible from the app.

An hour later, a WhatsApp message: the tour wasn't running tomorrow. Please cancel. I gently pointed out that I *couldn't* cancel — the cutoff had passed. What happened next still stops me when I think about it.

The tour operator came to our hotel. In person. Handed us the refund in cash. Apologised — repeatedly, deeply, in the way only a Japanese apology lands. There was no email, no "5–7 business days," no help-desk script. Just a person, doing the right thing, at 9 p.m., because that's how things are done here.

We stood there a little stunned, money in hand. Then — small miracle — we found a different tour bus service with morning availability, booked it, and went to sleep. 8 a.m. departure from Sapporo Station. We could finally rest.

Day 2: 30th April

The Sunrise That Tried to Trick Us

I woke up to a room full of light, sat up bolt upright, certain we had slept through everything. The clock said **4:30 a.m.** Hokkaido in late spring does not believe in dawn the way the rest of us do — the sun is just *up*, fully committed, by half-four. (This, dear reader, is why hotels here issue blackout curtains as a moral imperative.) We laughed, lay back down, then got up properly and made it to the bus stop early.

Why We're Tour-Bus People Now

We're usually the "make our own itinerary, decode the timetable, walk everywhere" couple. Day 2 converted us, at least for Hokkaido. **Travelling with a guide and a bus means no maps, no transfers, no logistics tax.** The guide narrates the history as the countryside slides past. The stops are timed but never rushed. You eat, you nap, you stare out the window — and someone else carries the cognitive load.

We'd booked last-minute, so we got the **back row**. Underrated. You can fully recline, eat without an audience, and nobody is watching you do anything. Last-row life is good life.

Noboribetsu Hell Valley · Yes, Earned the Name

First stop: **Noboribetsu Hell Valley**. Volcanic terrain, sulphur in the air, steam rising from cracks in red-orange rock. It looks like a film set — the name is, for once, completely literal.

An honest aside: we've seen New Zealand's geothermal landscapes, and that earlier benchmark may have unfairly stolen Noboribetsu's thunder for us. (We're biased. We admit it.) On its own, it's *spectacular*. Just don't visit New Zealand first, is all I'm saying.

Bear Ranch & Mount Usu · The Skip We Don't Regret

Next: the **Bear Ranch and Mount Usu Ropeway**. Honest confession — we didn't take the gondola up, and we didn't pay to see the bears. Standing at the base, weighing the tickets against the queue, it just didn't feel like our kind of memory. So we used the time to shop instead: **Hokkaido chocolates** (worth the suitcase weight), a **vegan ramen** bowl that warmed us right through, and — yes — **another ice cream**. Hokkaido's dairy is famous because each region's milk tastes a little different, so every soft-serve is a slightly different soft-serve. Research, basically.

Lake Toya & the Two Surprise Farms

Then **Lake Toya**. Huge, calm, mountain-ringed — the kind of view that makes the whole bus go quiet. Our tour also rolled us through **two local farms** we didn't have on any list, each with their own yogurt and their own ice cream. We tried all of them. It is at this point on the trip that we accepted Hokkaido is a place you *ice-cream your way through*, and stopped pretending otherwise.

Back in Sapporo · Odori, TV Tower & One More Donguri Run

We rolled back into Sapporo by **4 p.m.** with enough light and energy to walk through **Odori Park** — the famous green spine that cuts the city in half — and ride up the **Sapporo TV Tower** for a low-key but lovely city view. Dinner was, predictably, dysfunctional: a Subway sandwich (don't judge), followed by a *second* raid on **Donguri** because the first one was clearly insufficient research. We wandered the market, walked back to the Park Hotel, packed our bags. Early flight to Tokyo in the morning.

Hokkaido is the version of Japan no one warns you about — quieter, colder, bigger, and somehow more generous. Two days were not enough. Two weeks would be a good start.

Where It All Happened

Two days, one big island, a surprising amount of ground. Pan the map, click a pin — each one is a story above.

Must-Do in Sapporo

Our Two-Day Shortlist

- **Hill of the Buddha** · Tadao Ando's tunnel reveal — go even though it's far.
- **Late-season sakura** · Get off the bus a stop early and walk it.
- **Pole Town Arcade** · Warm, endless, gloriously confusing.
- **Donguri & Kintoya Bake** · Pastry haul, no regrets.
- **Hokkaido ice cream** · Anywhere. Everywhere. Multiple times.
- **Noboribetsu Hell Valley** · Volcanic, otherworldly, smells like sulphur.
- **Mount Usu Ropeway** · Crater lake on one side, ocean on the other.
- **Lake Toya & dairy farms** · Calm water, fresh yogurt, surprise stops.
- **Sapporo TV Tower & Odori Park** · A simple end-of-day city view.
- **Airport Limousine Bus** · The unsung hero of pre-dawn travel days.

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